

7.1. Upgrade To XP Service Pack 2

If you haven't yet updated your machine to Windows XP Service Pack 2 (SP2), do that now. Some programs—especially those that access the Internet in the background—will get broken due to the SP2 update. This is intentional. SP2 includes the Internet Connection Firewall, which blocks most TCP/IP ports. If your application uses a port not recognised by Windows, you will need to open the port for that application.

To find out what version of Windows XP you are using, right-click My Computer and select Properties. In the General tab of the System Properties dialog box, look for the description under System; it will tell you the version of the OS along with Service Pack information. If your computer does not have SP2, you can automatically update the software by visiting <http://windowsupdate.microsoft.com>.

SP2 is, however, a huge download. It's a somewhat complex upgrade. It could possibly cause your system to crash, and you could be left without a PC for days. You'd be better off contacting a professional who can do it for you in a day rather than be stuck with a failed upgrade.

If you plan to do it on your own make sure you follow the following steps:

1. Update your virus/adware definitions and scan your entire system.
2. If you have a software firewall, get the latest version. This will be SP2-compatible.
3. Get hardware driver updates from the manufacturers of all your hardware devices.
4. Back up all your software to CD/DVD.
5. Create a system restore point.
6. Restart your computer, disable anti-virus software and all other software that are currently running, make sure you are disconnected from the Internet, and only then access the SP2 update.